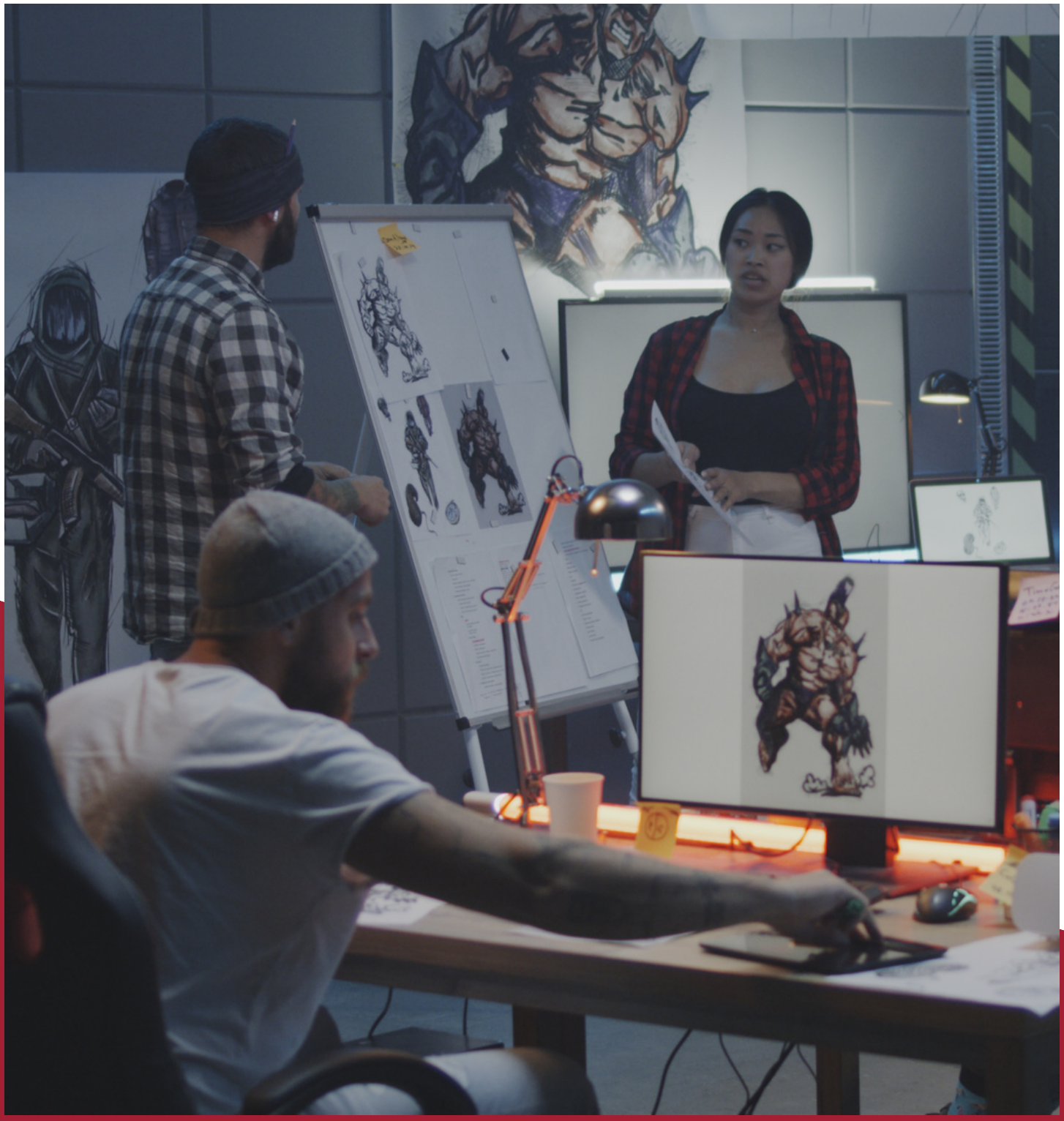


MIT | xPRO

PROFESSIONAL CERTIFICATE IN GAME DESIGN

Develop a future-ready toolkit of game design skills

Delivered in collaboration with EMERITUS

Overview

Games are timeless, universal, and capable of crossing boundaries. Advances in technology have contributed to a changing landscape of the gaming market. The video game segment is expected to reach $225.7 billion by 2025, and the board game segment is expected to set its own record, climbing to $30.93 billion by 2028. What is responsible for this surge? Games are permeating every aspect of life – from recreation to education and training.

New applications are creating the need for a generation of game design professionals who not only know how to design, develop, and launch games that foster connection and resonate with a diverse audience – but also have a sense for how to scope projects, manage products, and work effectively with teams.

Developed by experts from the MIT Game Lab, MIT xPRO's Professional Certificate in Game Design has been created to meet the growing demand for game designers who are ready to take on the challenges of today's market. The program encompasses the skills and best practices of modern game design, project management, and project scoping and prepares learners to design games that are culture conscious and accessible to larger audiences within society.

PRICE
USD 7,450

DURATION
6 months, Online
15-20 hours per week



USD 93,926

The average salary for lead designers in the United States

(Source: Payscale)

Program Highlights

Earn an MIT xPRO certificate and 36 continuing education units (CEUs)

Gain insights from MIT Game Lab instructors and guest speakers who are experts in the field and bring industry experience to the classroom

Compile a Game Diary, a portfolio of your work you can share with potential employers

Complete a capstone project by applying your knowledge and skills to develop a functional game

Receive one–on–one career support from Emeritus and introductions to hiring partners for eligible participants



Program Experience

20+ hours
of prerecorded MIT faculty videos

5+ hours
of live mentorship and career support*

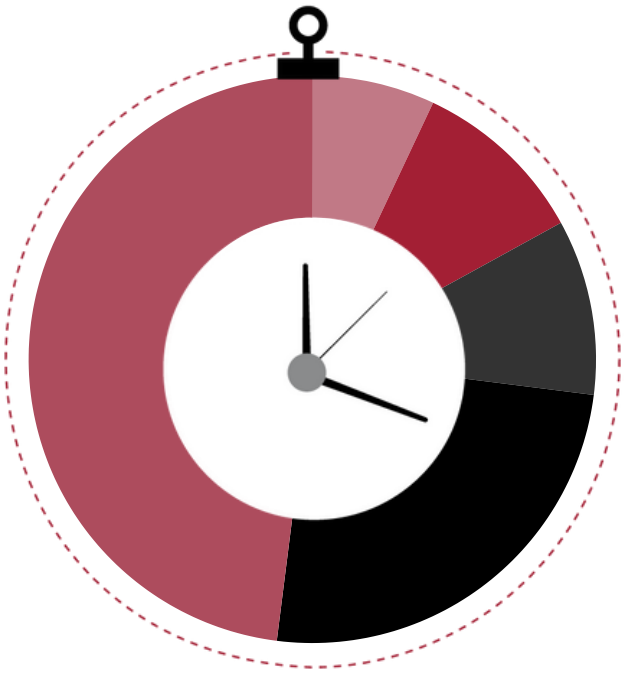
5+ hours
of live mentorship and career support*

19 career development video lectures covering **30** career topics*

Access to résumé referrals to Emeritus employer partners for up to **6 months** post–program*

Sample Weekly Program Planner

Learners should expect to dedicate a minimum of **15–20 hours** per week to the program.



- Live interaction with program learning facilitators**
- **1–2 hours** of recorded video lectures with faculty
- **1–2 hours** of engaging group discussion with peers to exchange and generate ideas
- **5–10 hours** of self–study (optional) and practice exercises
- **10–15 hours** of rigorous, graded assignments to apply and reinforce lecture material

*Services provided by Emeritus, a learning partner for this program.
**The schedule for live interactions are subject to change based on availability and will be confirmed once the program starts.

Learning Journey

From navigating the enrollment process to identifying job opportunities, we partner with you to take the next step in your career.

LEARNING FACILITATOR

Your learning facilitator will leverage their industry experience and expertise to guide you by holding live sessions, providing assignment feedback, and answering questions.

LEARNING COMMUNITY

Your learning community will provide an interactive environment where you can learn with a group of like-minded individuals and build a global network of peers.



PROGRAM ADVISOR

Your program advisor will be your enrollment resource, answering any pre-program questions and easing your transition into the program.

CAREER COACH

Your career coach will help you successfully navigate your job search by assisting with goal setting, providing feedback on your cover letter, résumé, and LinkedIn profile, and conducting mock interviews. They will be a source of up-to-the-minute information on hiring trends and help celebrate the next step in your career.

Who Is This Program For?

Whether you are a recent graduate, early career game professional, or creator, this program is designed to help you take advantage of unique opportunities in the field and advance your career.

The program will provide a distinct advantage for:



Recent graduates or postgraduates in fields such as information technology (IT), information technology-enabled services (ITeS), technology, or game development who are aiming to start a career in game design by demonstrating their capabilities through a program designed by renowned faculty from the MIT Game Lab



Early career game professionals looking to expand their career opportunities by gaining exposure to game design as a way to advance in a fast–growing field



Creative professionals, such as graphic or UX designers, sound engineers, production artists, or art directors, who have a passion for games of any type and wish to build upon their creative backgrounds to break into the game design industry

Prerequisites

Participants should have experience with basic coding concepts. Some assignments require the use of the Unity game engine (C#). Links to tutorials in Unity are provided.

Participants must be 18 or above to apply for this program.



Prepare for These Future Job Titles:

- Content Designer
- Game Programmer
- Narrative Designer
- User Experience Designer
- Game Designer
- User Interface Designer
- Level Designer
- Producer
- Lead Designer
- Senior–Level Designer
- Lead Animator
- Environment Artist
- User Interface Artist



Program Curriculum

Whether your interest is in board games or video games, this 6-month program gives you the opportunity to develop a wide spectrum of game design skills with the #1 technical school in the U.S. Drawing on the pursuit of innovative game design, social science research, and action-based interventions, the curriculum will help position you to take advantage of the demand for professionals who take a forward-thinking, inclusive approach to game design. This program's high-level learning outcomes include:

- Understanding the intricacies of game design by gaining in-depth knowledge of every stage
- Learning how to communicate effectively with a game design team by clearly outlining your vision and correctly scoping projects
- Future-proofing your career by learning how to design the games of tomorrow by focusing on considerations such as culture and accessibility
- Increasing your visibility with potential employers by creating a Gamer's Diary, a portfolio that highlights your expertise
- Learning from MIT expert instructors who actively practice game design and conduct research in MIT's Game Lab

Orientation

The first module is an orientation module. You will have access to the learning platform from the program start date. There is no teaching, but you can get comfortable navigating the site.

Note: All faculty lectures in this program are prerecorded.

Part 1

The Foundations of Game Design

Key Takeaways

- Use Tabletopia to recreate a game prototype
- Discover why rules need to be understandable and flexible
- Examine the dynamics of various play and game communities
- Learn how to analyze game mechanics
- Understand the roles and dynamics of adversarial and co-op gaming
- Discover how to analyze complex game systems involving feedback loops
- Understand the role of playtesting

Module 1: The Territory of Game Design	Module 2: Games, Rules, and Players
Module 3: Play Communities	Module 4: Building Blocks of Game Design
Module 5: Modes of Interaction	Module 6: Emergent Behavior

Part 2

Tabletop and Low Fidelity Prototyping

Key Takeaways

- Understand the connection between information and uncertainty in a game
- Learn to use appropriate ideation methodologies
- Construct a paper prototype
- Discover how to execute a playtesting cycle
- Find out how to assess the usability of an object
- Learn how to design a game for impact
- Construct a digital prototype

Module 7: The Territory of Game Design

Module 8: Games, Rules, and Players

Module 9: Play Communities

Module 10: Building Blocks of Game Design

Module 11: Modes of Interaction

Module 12: Emergent Behavior

Part 3

Using a Game Engine

Key Takeaways

- Discover how accessibility features can enhance the player experience
- Produce a build of a digital game
- Learn best practices for communicating with a team
- Understand how to apply the concepts of game feel
- Create a feature list for a game
- Understand the importance of environmental storytelling

Module 13: Inclusivity and Accessibility

Module 14: Digital Prototyping in Teams

Module 15: Development Practices

Module 16: Game Feel

Module 17: Project Scoping

Module 18: Opening the Black Box

Part 4

Putting It All Together

Key Takeaways

- Create an elevator pitch for a game
- Create a pitch deck for a business meeting
- Hear industry perspectives on starting an organization, game development, and sound design
- Design a game for the final capstone project

Module 13: Inclusivity and Accessibility

Module 14: Digital Prototyping in Teams

Module 15: Development Practices

Module 16: Game Feel

Module 17: Project Scoping

Module 18: Opening the Black Box

Assignments and Activities

Assignments

Reinforce key concepts through weekly assignments, such as designing a character, trying your hand at digital prototyping, and creating an elevator pitch.

Discussions and Interactive Activities

Play and analyze online games, tinker with a game framework in Unity, and exchange perspectives with other game design professionals from around the world.

Knowledge Checks

Test your knowledge of game design through short weekly assessments.

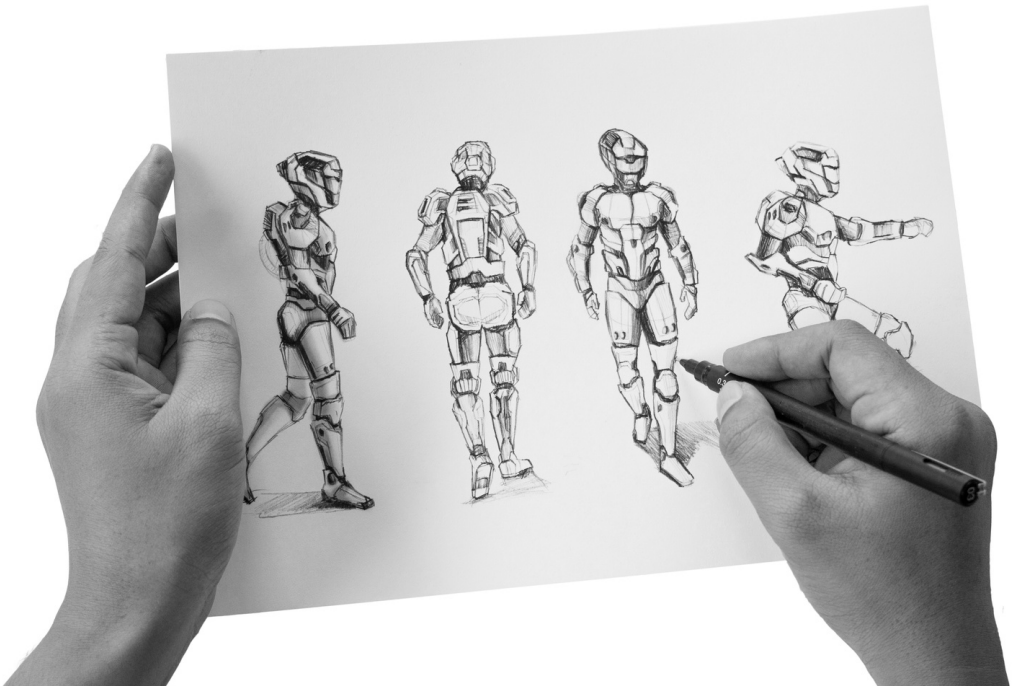
Experiential Projects

Game Diary

Make weekly entries detailing your experiences and observations, and build a portfolio of your work to share with potential employers.

Capstone Project

Highlight your knowledge and skills in a final capstone project by leading a game design project from conceptualization to functional design, and add it to your Game Diary as a testament to your expertise.



Program Instructors



PHILIP TAN

Research Scientist, MIT Game Lab

Philip Tan teaches courses in game design and production at MIT. His research translates the joy of expert challenge in scientific, professional, and competitive fields into playful forms that are accessible to anyone. For six years, he served as the executive director of the US operations of the Singapore–MIT GAMBIT Game Lab, a game research initiative. Philip has conducted research and development on projects with Blizzard Entertainment, Bose Corporation, Raytheon BBN, Fire Hose Games, and the Museum of Science in Boston.

In addition to his research and teaching, Philip served as an assistant manager at the Media Development Authority of Singapore, working closely with Singaporean game developers to launch industry-wide initiatives and administer content development grants. He has also served on the steering committee of the International Game Developers Association's Singapore chapter.

Early in his career, Philip produced and designed online PC games at The Education Arcade, an MIT research group that studied and created educational games. He complements his master's degree in comparative media studies with his work at the School of the Museum of Fine Arts, Boston; the MIT Media Lab; WMBR 88.1FM; and the MIT Assassins' Guild, where he earned the title of Master Assassin for his live–action roleplaying game designs. He also teaches DJ courses and founded a DJ crew at MIT.



MIKAEL JAKOBSSON

Research Scientist, MIT Game Lab

Mikael Jakobsson's interest in game development began in the 1980s, the age of early home computers. With a Bachelor's in Computer Science and a Master's in Informatics, he went on to write his dissertation on social interaction design in virtual worlds. Prior to his time with MIT, he also worked as a game reviewer for a major Swedish newspaper. His research interests converge at the intersection of game design and game culture. Building on a foundation in interaction design, he approaches his research using a combination of design exploration, interaction criticism, and participatory design, with the objective of strengthening the voices of underprivileged stakeholders.

Through his research, Mikael frequently collaborates with the game development community, including organizations such as Tencent, Ubisoft Massive, and King, and with other industry partners such as Bose Corporation and Boston Consulting Group. His work has been published extensively in leading game studies journals and anthologies, and he has coauthored a book with Professor Mary Flanagan scheduled for release from MIT Press in 2023. He has presented his research to a global audience, including the Game Developers Conference in San Francisco, Tencent in Beijing, and the UNESCO headquarters in Paris. He also teaches classes in game studies, game criticism, game design, and interaction design at undergraduate and graduate levels. He has 25 years of experience in teaching, developing courses, managing research projects, and advising master's and PhD students.

Guest Speakers



HEATHER ALBANO
Senior Narrative Designer, Deep Silver Volition,
Freelance Fiction Writer

Areas of expertise:
Narrative design and player agency



EITAN GLINERT
Founder and President, Fire Hose Games

Areas of expertise:
Starting your own company and deciding what game to create



RICHARD LUDLOW
Audio Director and Cofounder, Hexany Audio

Areas of expertise:
Sound design in games



JESSICA "JYNNIE" TANG
Product Manager and Game Developer,
Multiverse

Areas of expertise:
Working in and structuring teams, and combating toxicity

Career Preparation and Guidance

This program offers a wide array of career support and guidance to help you develop your career path. These services are provided by Emeritus, our learning collaborator for this program, via the Emeritus Career Center (ECC). The primary goal is to help you build the skills needed to prepare for your career, however we do not guarantee job placement. Learn more about all of the services and support available to you, including:

A SUPPORT TEAM YOU CAN RELY ON

Your support team includes program leaders and career coaches who will help you reach your learning goals and guide you through your job search.

CAREER PREPARATION SERVICES THAT GET YOU NOTICED

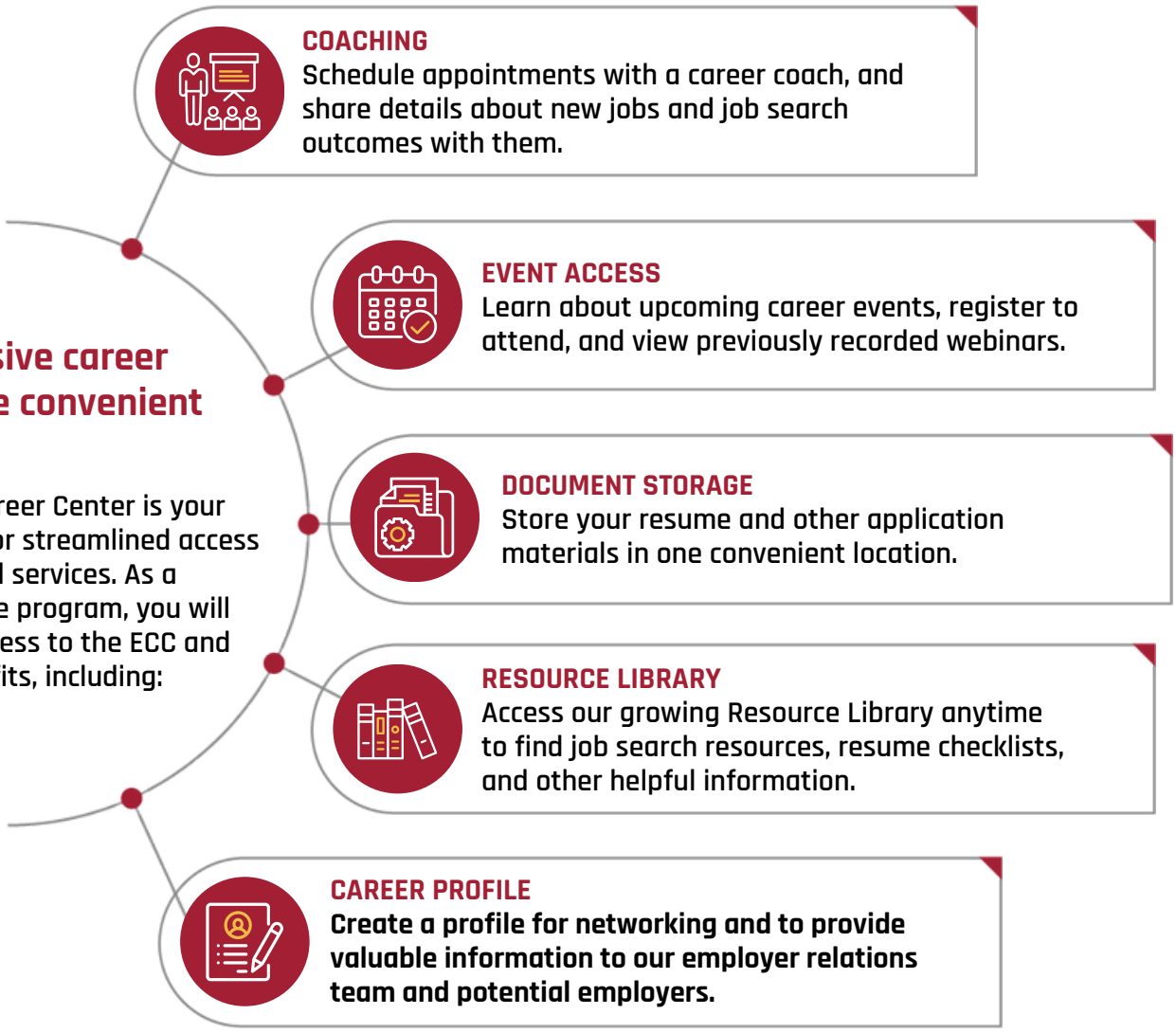
- Write noteworthy resumes and cover letters
- Create effective LinkedIn profiles
- Navigate your job search
- Prepare for interviews
- Craft your elevator pitch
- Negotiate your salary



Emeritus Career Center

Comprehensive career services. One convenient location.

The Emeritus Career Center is your one-stop shop for streamlined access to career-related services. As a participant in the program, you will gain lifetime access to the ECC and its related benefits, including:



These services are provided by Emeritus, our learning collaborator for this program.

UNLOCK ADDITIONAL BENEFITS: SHARE YOUR RESUME

Upload your resume to the ECC for approval and take advantage of:

- A resume review and feedback from your career coach.
- Access to the job board, with postings from our employer partners and others seeking talent.
- An easy application process and the ability to track your application steps.
- Inclusion in resume books that our employer relations team will refer to employers.

Emeritus Hiring Partners

Professional Certificate in Game Design is designed to equip you with the in-demand skills that employers seek. The program support team includes dedicated career coaches to guide you through your job search. However, a job placement is not guaranteed.

Over the course of the program, you will gain access to customized recruiting plans developed in collaboration with our hiring partners, connect with hiring managers, obtain personal and industry feedback, and participate in virtual events. Our Employer Partners include:

TensorIoT

PARKER DEWEY

celero
accelerated commerce

CBRE

ttec

accenture

Our Graduates Work At

Resource Library

Duke-Energy Corporation

Ingenovis Health

Marsh McLennan

Financing Options

We want to make sure that the Professional Certificate in Game Design program is an affordable option for all. This is why we offer you multiple different ways to pay for the program.

Loan Partner (For US Residents)

Climb Credit	Immediate repayment, interest-only repayment, and deferred payment options are available.

- Visit the Climb Credit application portal
- Fill in your basic details and proceed to the loan section of the application
- Select your course from the program dropdown
- Choose your preferred repayment option and enter financial information
- Agree to the disclosure and submit your application
- Once approved, sign the Master Promissory Note
- Our program advisors will contact you for a confirmation on your loan application
- After confirmation, we will certify your loan. You will receive a welcome email with login instructions from notifications@instructure.com within 3 business days

Sallie Mae Loan	Learn more and apply

(Select 'Student' and 'Undergraduate Student' to proceed)

Flexible Payment Options (For All Countries)

- Choose to make your payment in two, three, or six installments for more flexibility.
- Complete your application for the Professional Certificate in Game Design, and enroll in the program.

You can opt for any one of the financing options to cover up to the full cost of the program tuition. If you are considering financing your program through one of our partners, the enrollment process can only be completed with the assistance of your program advisor or by calling +1 315 640 4846.

*Due to processing time, the loan application should be submitted no later than four business days prior to the enrollment deadline.

Certificate

Get recognized! Upon successful completion of this program, MIT xPRO grants a certificate of completion to participants and 36 Continuing Education Units (CEUs). This program is graded as a pass or fail; participants must receive 75% to pass and obtain the certificate of completion.

After successful completion of the program, your verified digital certificate will be emailed to you, at no additional cost, in the name you used when registering for the program. All certificate images are for illustrative purposes only and may be subject to change at the discretion of MIT.



About MIT xPRO

MIT xPRO's online learning programs leverage vetted content from world-renowned experts to make learning accessible anytime, anywhere. Designed using cutting-edge research in the neuroscience of learning, MIT xPRO programs are helping professionals build their skills on the job. To explore the full catalog of MIT xPRO courses and programs, visit xpro.mit.edu.

About Emeritus

MIT xPRO is collaborating with online education provider Emeritus to deliver this online program through a dynamic, interactive, digital learning platform. This program leverages MIT xPRO's thought leadership in engineering and management practice developed over years of research, teaching, and practice.

Easily schedule a call with a program advisor from Emeritus to learn more about this MIT xPRO program.

SCHEDULE A CALL

You can apply for the program here:

APPLY

Refer your colleague and receive a benefit:

REFER NOW

Connect with a program advisor:

Email: learner.success@emeritus.org
Phone: +1 315 640 4846 (U.S.)
+44 141 673 6416 (U.K.)
+65 3138 2327 (Singapore)

MIT xPRO

Delivered in collaboration with

EMERITUS